

Paradise UpRooted

In an effort to produce more affordable housing and reduce the number of city-owned vacant lots the Giuliani administration has decided to sell off hundreds of parcels of real-estate. An appropriate decision in light of improved municipal finances and the New York City Partnership's New Homes Program, which injects \$100 million per year in public and private funds into residential construction. Empty lots in some of the city's poorest neighborhoods have been slated for residential and commercial development. Clearly the city is in need of housing for low- to moderate-income families, and many neighborhoods would benefit from new commercial businesses and services. But like most things in New York, it comes at a price.

In this case, hundreds of community gardens have been given notice that their year-to-year leases will not be renewed. In this year alone 45 gardens throughout the city will be plowed under. Operation GreenThumb, a program of NYC's Department of Parks and Recreation, reports that during the next five years 350 of its 750 gardens will be affected. Most will be lost to bulldozers, some will be relocated, and it seems likely that a few prominent sites that have demonstrated a sustained commitment to public access and public programming will be saved.

Many of these gardens have been around for 20 years or more. Back in the 1960s, in the midst of white flight and rampant disinvestment, abandoned and burned out buildings were pulled down as landlords walked away from their investments and responsibilities. Derelict lots and their neighboring buildings became dumping grounds, open drug markets and havens for other criminal activity. The government's response was to throw up its hands and

wait for the real-estate market to remedy the situation. But, for the residents who lived in these neighborhoods, like the Lower East Side and Harlem, time was against them and they couldn't wait for the market or the government to act.

Thousands of people in neighborhoods throughout the city with modest resources, hard work and lots of imagination transformed these festering sores into urban oases. In the process strangers became neighbors, the social fiber of the community was strengthened and new community leaders emerged. New York City's urban gardening movement not only created green spaces in neighborhoods bereft of park land, but it also provided safe places for people to congregate, opportunities for cultural expression and celebrations, and some even became earth science classrooms for neighboring schools. Community gardens have had a profound affect on the urban landscape.

Since the movement's inception, artists such as Liz Christy, the founder of Green Guerillas and creator of the Bowery-Houston garden, have been integral to its success. The gardens have been sites for murals, sculptures, performances and rituals. For the past two decades through the efforts of creative individuals and nonprofit groups like Earth Celebrations the gardens have become a place where art and other forms of cultural expression are integrated into the daily lives of New Yorkers. The urban garden expresses the character and spirit of the people who tend it, in that respect it is a genuine and organic aspect of urban culture and for that reason alone it is worth preserving.

After two decades of success it is evident that the green movement has not taken root in the city's planning process. The city's policies and actions in this area of community activism are ad hoc and incoherent, so much so that the agencies responsible for the sell off *seem* to be unaware of the gardens even though Operation Green Thumb is within a city agency. The administration's insistence of moving forward with the mass destruction of these gardens reveals an institutionalized indifference to the city's volunteer gardeners specifically and community-based planning in general.

As citizens we shouldn't really have to choose between affordable housing and gardens. The real issue is that we need community-sensitive development plans for the disposition of city-owned land — plans that acknowledge the positive benefits derived from active community gardens open to the public and offering cultural events. While every garden cannot be saved, the city should first attempt to develop unused lots before up-rooting community gardens. After all, the gardens enhance the quality of life in these neighborhoods adding value to any future development.

If you would like more information or learn how you can get involved, these are the folks to contact: Operation Green Thumb (NYC Department of Parks & Recreation), (212) 788-8059; Green Guerillas, (212) 674-8124; Neighborhood Open Space Coalition, (212) 513-7555; Council on the Environment of New York City, Open Space Greening Program, (212) 788-7913. —J.M. Clark

Sculpture by Eddie Borof. Photo by Margaret Morton.

